GALLIFY

Building Gallify, and deciding to wind it down

Gallify was an iOS app where digital artists could put up a gallery in a few minutes and collectors could hang the work on their own wall in AR before buying it. I joined early, became Chief Product and Operating Officer, and ran product and engineering until we closed the company.

ROLE
Co-Founder, CPO/COO

TEAM
8 to 10 engineers in 4 sub-teams

STACK
iOS, ARKit, Object Capture, Solidity on Polygon

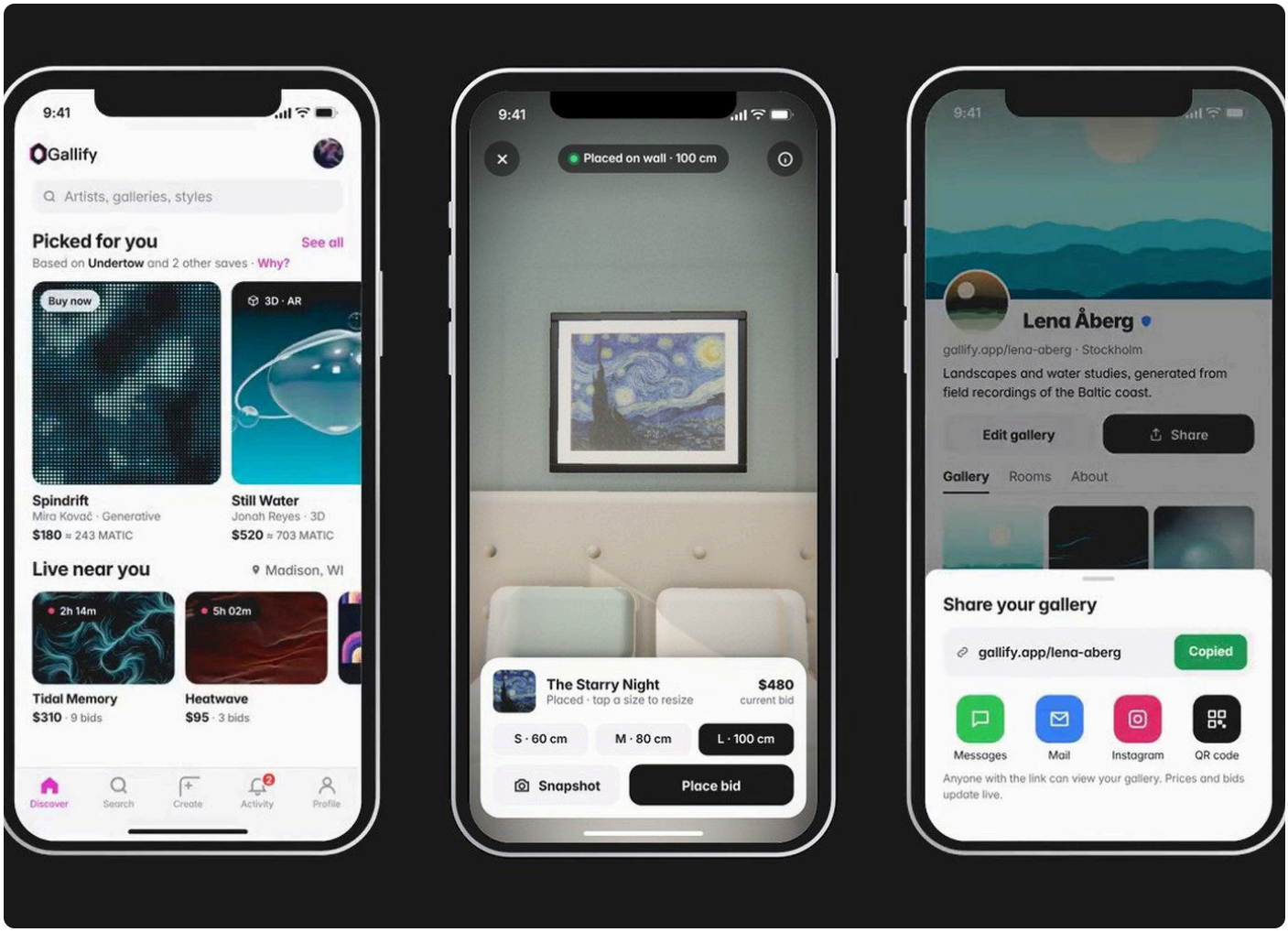
Code on GitHub **github.com/profio1997/Gallify_App**

+20%
click-through from recommendations

+10%
average order value

60→85%
on-time delivery

3 → 10+
engineers hired

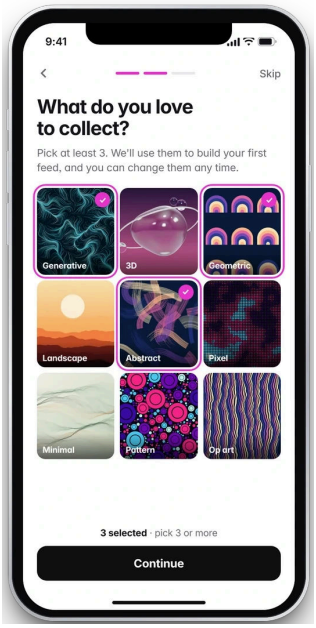


Overview

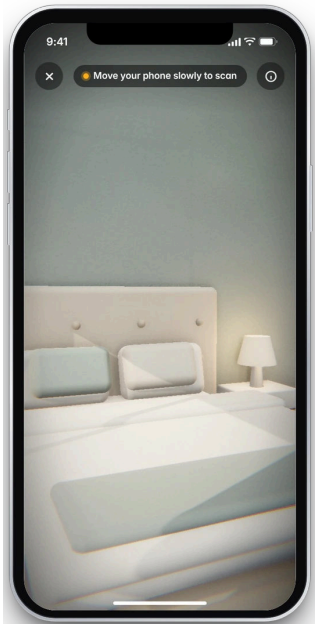
Gallify taught me more than any other job about building a product, and about stopping one. It started as a small AI-focused team. I was hand-picked for my technical skills and for how I worked with others, and I ended up as Chief Product and Operating Officer and a co-founder. Over five years I led product, ran engineering through a lot of hiring, and in the end recommended that we wind the company down.

Digital artists had nowhere to show and sell their work that felt like a gallery. Collectors couldn't see a piece in their own space, and couldn't prove they owned it. So we built an iOS app with galleries you could create and share in minutes, AR to see any piece on your wall at its real size, and ownership recorded on a blockchain.

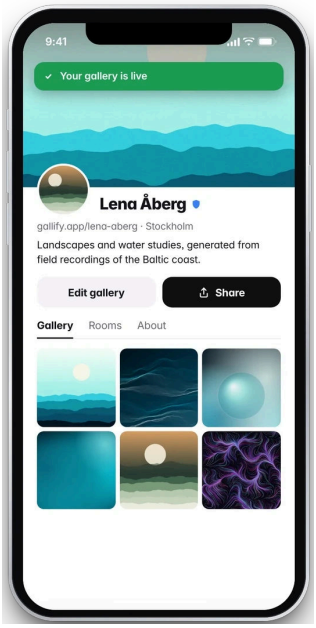
This page covers the product decisions, the recommender I led, how I ran the team, and the decision to stop.



Collector setup and discovery: pick a few styles, get a first feed built from them, then tap "Why?" to see and adjust what a pick is based on.



AR in a real room: walk around, place the piece on the wall at its real size, resize it, take a snapshot, then bid from the same screen.

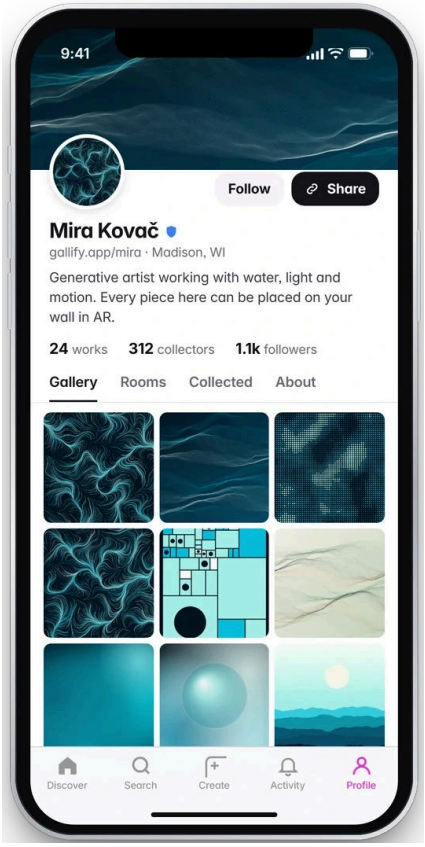


The artist side: add works, mint each as 1 of 1, publish a gallery and share its link.

Problem and research

Back then digital art mostly lived on social feeds built for photos. Artists could post, but there was no place that treated a piece of digital work with the presence a gallery gives a painting. For collectors there were two gaps. They couldn't tell how a piece would look at home, which is how most people decide to buy art. And they had no reliable way to prove they owned what they bought.

Our positioning was "a next generation gallery for the digital age", meaning you create a gallery and share it instantly. We bet that seeing a piece on your own wall and being able to verify you owned it would make digital art feel like it counted, and that good discovery would help collectors find work they'd never have searched for.



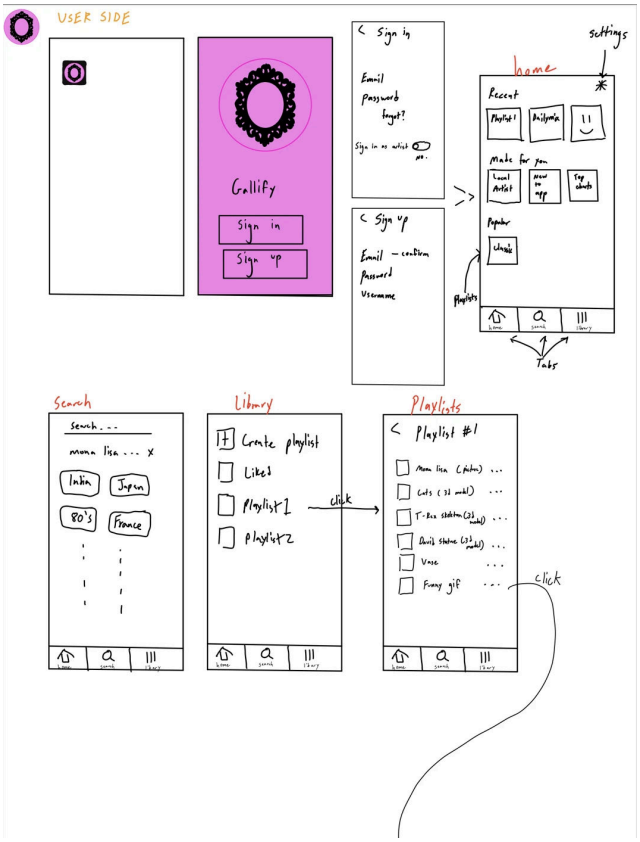
Each artist gets a gallery and a link to share it.

Discovery and early design

We started with flows before screens. I sketched sign-up, the library, playlists and search by hand and argued over the paths with the team until we agreed on them. Only then did we move to high-fidelity iOS designs, and after that to a beta landing page with a Discord community for early feedback.

The sketches cover what mattered at the start: how an artist creates a gallery, how a collector builds a library of favourites, and how playlists let people share taste. A few of those ideas survived and a lot of them didn't. Starting on paper meant changing our minds cost us nothing.

The beta page said "Create a gallery and share, instantly," and we used that sentence to test every feature. Did it make the first gallery faster to create, or easier to share?



Early flow sketches for sign-up, library, playlists and search.

Solution

Product decisions

Discovery over search

Collectors rarely know what to search for, so the home screen is a per-collector feed with local auctions by city, curated playlists and a featured room, instead of a search bar.

AR as the differentiator

We built on Apple's ARKit so collectors could place a piece on their own wall at real size before bidding. Later we added Object Capture so artists could scan physical sculptures into 3D and show those in AR too.

Ownership on a blockchain

Purchases are tokens on Polygon (an ERC-721 contract written in Solidity) with wallet connect, so a purchase meant verifiable ownership. Polygon's low fees and fast confirmation suited small first purchases by new collectors.

Collectors keep their own keys

Bids and purchases are approved in the collector's own wallet. Gallify never holds anyone's keys, which meant fewer security obligations for us and more trust for them.

Lower the bar for artists

Publishing a gallery from a phone takes minutes: upload images or capture a 3D piece, mint the work as a one-of-one, and share one link.

How the pieces fit together

IOS APP
Auctions, discovery, galleries and profiles, built in Swift for iPhone

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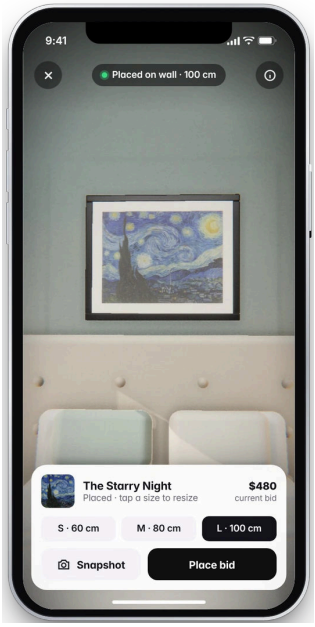
AR LAYER
ARKit places any piece on a wall at real size; Object Capture turns physical work into 3D

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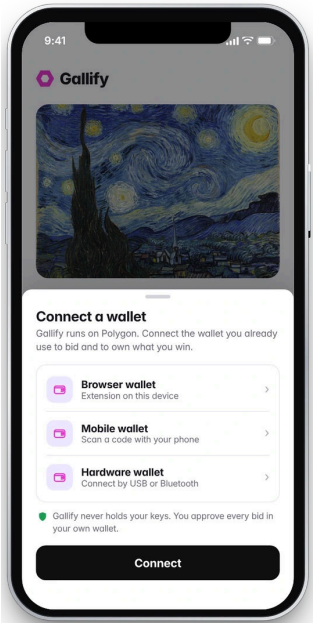
OWNERSHIP
Solidity smart contracts on Polygon issue each piece as a one-of-one token

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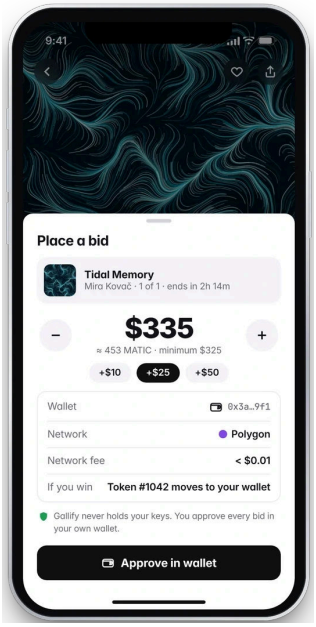
WALLET
The collector approves every bid and purchase in their own wallet



AR in a bedroom: the piece hangs above the bed at its real size.



Connecting a Polygon wallet before the first bid.

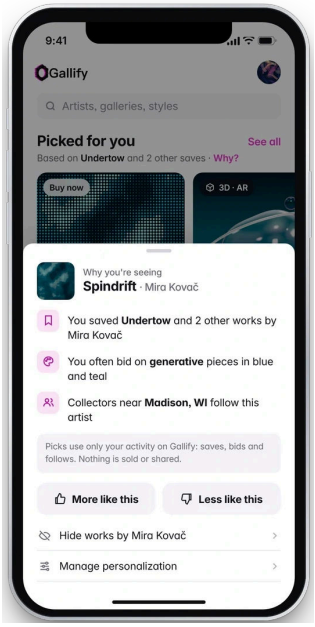


A bid, approved in the collector's own wallet.

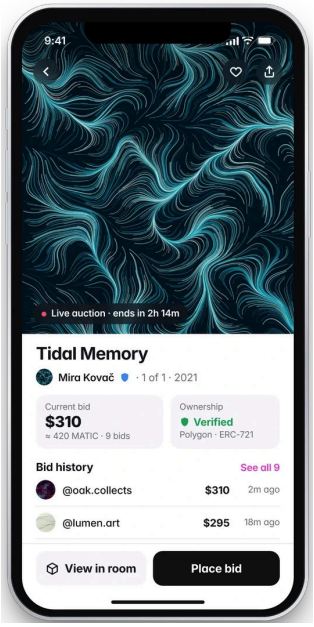
The recommender

I led the AI recommender for listings. Collectors arrived without a clear idea of what they wanted, and every artist wanted to be seen, so a feed that put the right piece in front of the right person was the most valuable thing we could build.

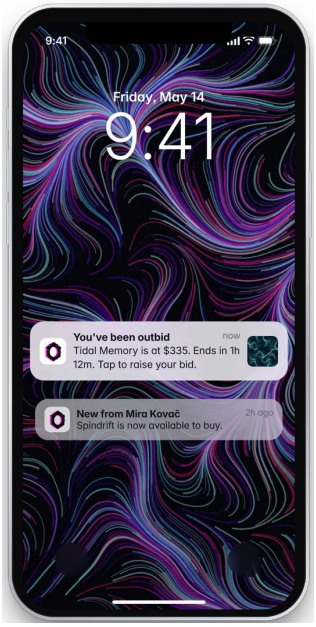
It ranked live auctions and listings for each collector from what they had viewed, saved, bid on and bought, plus each piece's style, medium and artist. New collectors picked a few styles they liked first so the feed wasn't empty on day one. Each pick had a reason behind it, and collectors could ask for more or less of something, or hide an artist. We measured the feed against our previous ordering, looking at click-through and at average order value rather than time in the app. Click-through rose 20% and average order value 10%.



Tapping "Why?" shows what a pick was based on and lets the collector adjust it.



A listing with live bidding and verified ownership.



An outbid alert while the auction is still running.

How the recommender worked

SIGNALS	RANKING	EXPLANATION	MEASURED ON
Views, saves, bids and purchases; each piece's style, medium and artist; taste picks for new collectors	Live auctions and listings, ordered for each collector and refreshed as they browse	A reason for each pick, with more, less and hide controls	Click-through and average order value, compared with the previous feed

Trade-offs I'd flag

Two of our biggest bets were also our riskiest, and each one cost us something.

AR. It was the feature people remembered, and nothing else felt like our product. It was also a big engineering investment that only paid off if enough collectors cared about seeing a piece in their room. People loved the moment. We never got clear evidence that it made them buy.

Blockchain. On-chain ownership solved the real problem of proving a piece is yours. It also added friction. New collectors had to set up a wallet before they could bid, which is a lot to ask before they've seen a single piece they love. We kept fees low on Polygon and made the wallet step as clear as we could, but it still cost us growth.

Team, results and the shutdown

Running the team

By our busiest period we had six projects running across four sub-teams of eight to ten engineers. I was Scrum Master and also the main technical decision-maker, which meant setting product priorities and engineering standards. Delivery was unreliable when I took it on. Here's what I changed.

- **Rhythm.** I set up regular sprints and one-on-ones, so problems surfaced in a week instead of at the deadline.
- **Standards.** I wrote down engineering standards, including what "done" meant, so quality didn't depend on who was reviewing.
- **Hiring.** I ran the whole process, from sourcing to onboarding, as we grew from 3 engineers to more than 10, and recruited more than 15 people across the company.
- **Onboarding.** I documented the codebase and the way we worked so new engineers could contribute sooner.

DELIVERY MEASURE	RESULT
On-time delivery	**From about 60% to 85%**
Average bug resolution time	**About 35% faster**
Team velocity	**About 30% higher, with scope and budget within 10% of projections**
Time to productivity for new engineers	**About 25% shorter**
Active projects	**All 6 delivered on schedule, within 8% of estimates on average; production incidents under 2% of deployments**

Over five years we shipped three major releases. They covered marketplace transactions on the blockchain, the AR gallery experience and the iOS app itself, and we designed, built and launched the platform ahead of schedule. The recommender gave us the 20% and 10% lifts described above.

OUTCOME	RESULT
Click-through from recommendations	**+20%**
Average order value	**+10%**

OUTCOME	RESULT
Major releases	**3+: marketplace transactions, AR galleries, iOS**
Platform	**Designed, built and launched ahead of schedule**
Business	**Did not reach product-market fit; wound down**

Winding it down

The product worked. People used the AR view, and the recommendations measurably moved sales. What we never found was product-market fit. The group of collectors who wanted to buy digital art this way stayed small, and our delivery numbers, however good, didn't change that.

I recommended that we stop. It was the hardest call I've made. Every month we kept going was a month the team put into a bet that wasn't paying off, and I knew that when I made it. Closing the company carefully, with its people, code and commitments, taught me almost as much as building it did.

Before deciding I looked at four things: whether the people who tried Gallify came back, whether new collectors kept arriving without us pushing, whether we could afford another year of the same bet, and whether the team was still excited about it. None of the answers pointed toward continuing. I told the team directly, did what I could for the people who had put years into it, and made the app's code public so the work could still be seen. It's on GitHub today.

What I'd do differently

- We built AR and blockchain ownership before we had proof that enough collectors wanted them. Today I'd test demand first with something much cheaper, like a landing page, a handful of artists and a manual version of the experience.
- Our delivery numbers improved a lot, and they still told us nothing about product-market fit. I now decide up front which retention number would justify continuing, and I look at it every month.
- Stopping was the right decision. I would make it sooner.
- Telling users why a piece is shown, and letting them change it, was cheap to build and gave us a clearer signal than clicks alone. I'd do it from the start on any recommender.